Winners and losers in the Suez War

Key question
Who won and who lost the Suez War?

Nasser: hero of the Arab world

Nasser, the Egyptian leader, became the hero of the Arab world. He had stood up to Britain and France, who had dominated the Middle East for so long. He had gained complete control of the Suez Canal and of a large quantity of British military stores. With US aid the Canal was cleared and reopened in April 1957. Although Egypt lost territory when the Israelis captured Sinai, the Israelis were persuaded, by the Americans, to withdraw early in 1957. Besides, Nasser could claim that the Egyptian army had only been defeated because the Israelis had British and French support.

The Israelis

The Israelis also made gains. The speed of their victory over Egyptian forces in Gaza and Sinai had proved that the Israeli Defence Forces were the strongest in the Middle East. When they withdrew from Sinai, UN troops moved in to guard the border between Egypt and Israel. In particular, UN forces were sent to Gaza to prevent more raids on Israel and to Sharm-el-Sheikh (see map on page 42) to guard the passage of Israeli shipping through the Straits of Tiran.

Britain and France

The undoubted losers of the Suez War were Britain and France. They had failed to regain control of the Canal and they had failed to overthrow Nasser. The British lion was forced to slope off with its tail between its legs. The long period of Anglo-French domination of the Arab world was ending.

The effects of the war

One of the main effects of the Suez crisis was to make many of the Arab states more anti-Western than ever. Not only had Britain and France tried to overthrow the government of the leading Arab nation, but they had used Israel to do so. Now, more then ever before, Israel looked like an outpost of Western imperialism. The Arabs became more willing to seek Soviet aid. The Soviet Union now began to supply most of Egypt's weapons and to pay for the building of the Aswan Dam and many other projects. However, Nasser did not want Egypt to be tied to the Soviet Union and he was certainly not a communist. He wanted Egypt and the other Arab states to be neutral. (This is discussed more fully in Chapter 4.)

In 1964, Nasser invited the leaders of the Arab states to a conference in Cairo. Although many of them mistrusted each other, one thing united them all: opposition to the state of Israel and support for the Palestinians.